

The Use of Cookbooks to Understand Archaeological Evidence



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Cookbooks have been used before to study the ways in which foods were prepared and ultimately incorporated into cuisines. We have Roman recipes, especially from the cookbook known as *de re culinaria* ("about cooking") or by the name of its purported author, *Apicius* (<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Apicius>). This cookbook is believed to have been composed originally in the first century CE, possibly by multiple individuals. Archaeologists studying early Euro-Americans in Boston have used cookbooks of that era to understand how those people might have prepared food both for their families and for guests. But Popper faced the challenge that Chinese immigrants of 19th-century California did not cook following established, written recipes, instead learning them through family and other social connections and making them from memory. So Popper employed a form of analogy in her reasoning: "[T]his article turned to 20th century cookbooks not for specific recipes used in Market Street Chinatown, but for the basic principles of Chinese cuisine that would have been familiar to the Chinese migrants" (Popper, 2019, p. 348). She also notes that "because these cookbooks were written in the 20th century for an English-speaking audience of ample means to purchase a variety of products, they cannot be used uncritically to discuss 19th century Chinatown cuisine" (Popper, 2019, p. 349). But given these limitations, cookbooks help to inform the list of food items produced by archaeologists and turn them into an idea of dishes and cuisine.

The earliest English-language Chinese cookbooks printed in the U.S. date to the second decade of the 20th century. Popper notes that these contain little context, however, and so cookbooks from the middle of the 20th century are more useful in understanding the context of Chinese cuisine in the U.S., as well as the specifics of Cantonese cuisine. She notes the long-standing importance of two components of a meal: *fan*—rice or noodles (or occasionally another staple grain)—and *tsai*, seasoned side dishes of vegetables or meat. A second division is between "eating materials"—the key ingredients of a meal—and "cooking materials," which include the liquid medium for heating the food, salts, sweeteners, spices, flavoring agents, binders, and garnishes. Popper notes that the cooking materials are less likely to be represented archaeologically, as they were often used in small amounts and then ground or fermented into liquid before use. For example, soybeans were absent in the archaeological assemblage, but ceramic pots used to hold soy sauce were numerous. Understanding the principles of Chinese cuisine helps archaeologists understand why certain food items might be underrepresented in the archaeological assemblage.

These cookbooks also helped Popper to understand the context of Euro-American ingredients in Chinese cooking, such as the role of beef—not a traditional meat in Cantonese cuisine even into the early 20th century. Yet cattle bones are abundant in Market Street Chinatown, indicating that its residents adapted beef into their traditional recipes, although adjustments must have been required to adapt to its toughness and taste. The role of tomatoes is more complex: They appear to have become established in urban Cantonese cuisine in China, but possibly not in rural cooking, so it is ambiguous whether the ready adoption of tomatoes by residents of Market Street Chinatown predates or postdates their arrival in California. Popper also points out that these cookbooks neglect the important topic of health and medicine, and the medicinal qualities of foods would have been equally important in choosing ingredients for a dish. Nonetheless, Popper notes that using cookbooks "provides a more intimate view of daily activities related to food preparation and eating. They can help to put us in Chinese kitchens and around dining tables and can help us understand the choices made by cooks and diners" (2019, p. 354).